

Extensive Commentary on the Praise Surpassing the Gods

Deva-atīśaya-stotra-ṭīkā · Toh 1113 · Derge Tengyur

ལ་ལྷ་མ་ཡ་དྲ་བའི་བསྐྱོད་པའི་རྒྱུ་རྒྱུ་ལྟེན་པ།

Toh 1113 in the Tengyur is an extensive Indian commentary known in Sanskrit as the Deva-atīśaya-stotra-ṭīkā and in Tibetan as the Lha las phul du byung bar bstod pa'i rgya cher 'grel pa, rendered in English as the Extensive Commentary on the Praise Surpassing the Gods. It belongs to the genre of stotra literature — works of devotional praise — and serves as a detailed exegetical commentary on a hymn celebrating the Buddha as one who surpasses even the gods, a theme developed in part through a narrative involving two brahmin brothers whose encounter with Buddhist teaching leads them to recognize the Buddha's supreme qualities. The text opens with homage to Mañjuśrī in his youthful form, a conventional dedication that situates the work within the Mahāyāna tradition. It was requested by the monk Paltsek Rakshita and definitively established in its Tibetan form, indicating it passed through the standard process of translation and editorial review that characterized the production of the Tengyur collection.

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In the Sanskrit language: Deva-atīśaya-stotra-ṭīkā. In the Tibetan language: The Extensive Commentary on the Praise Surpassing the Gods.

Homage to the Blessed One Mañjuśrī in his youthful form.

The Teacher of peace, surpassing the gods,
To him I bow with faith and reverence,
And now this Praise Surpassing the Gods
I shall analyze to the best of my ability.

Having heard what follows, know that two brothers — one named Mthobtsun Drubjé and the other Dejyed Dakpo — were born into a brahmin family devoted to their own religious duties and holding supreme faith in the Great God (Śiva). Likewise, both of them became accomplished in all the treatises. Then they thought to themselves: "So long as we have not seen the Great God face to face and received his prophetic declaration, we two shall not perform even the slightest root of virtue." Having resolved this, they went to the Yellow Mountain, and there they encountered the Great God engaged in the practice of distributing alms to a community of arhat monks. From that encounter it

was made clear to them that the buddha, the Blessed One himself, is the supreme teacher of all three existences. Gaining certainty, they entered into the Buddha's teaching, and relying upon it, Mthobtsun Drubjé composed a praise of the buddha, the Blessed One, with a hymn of especially exalted quality, while Dejyed Dakpo composed a praise of the Lord of Sages (Śākyamuni) with the Praise Surpassing the Gods.

Now, in order to compose an extensive explanation of that praise called "Surpassing the Gods," the words that open that explanation are spoken — namely "the buddha, the Blessed One," and so forth. The reason these words are spoken is the following. If someone were to compose a praise of the Victor on the grounds that he is endowed solely with supremely excellent qualities, other opponents might argue: "This is an approach based on faith alone and is not correct." Therefore the text is spoken in reliance upon reasoning. Although the Teacher who surpasses all sentient beings cannot be seen directly at the present time, and there is no yogic perception of him either — in other words, while he has not become directly perceptible to these parties, for Brahma and others he is not seen with unobstructed clarity — nonetheless, through inference, two teachers who correctly guide beings in all three realms are well known: for ordinary worldly people, it is known that Brahma and the like serve as teachers, while for noble persons endowed with realization, it is known that the buddha, the Blessed One, is the teacher. Since none of them can see these teachers directly, the text says "he has not become directly perceptible."

The epithet "Blessed One" (bhagavat) means he has defeated the adversary of the afflictions together with their habitual tendencies; this expresses the perfection of abandonment.

The epithet Sugata, "Well-Gone," means he has gone well because he has understood the meaning without error and precisely; this expresses the perfection of wisdom.

The name "Viṣṇu" (Khyabjuk, the All-Pervader) means he pervades through various acts of subjugation. He is so called because he subdues all three worlds. It is said that from the lotus of his navel Brahma was born, and from him in turn other beings also arose.

The Great God — since he draws beings together, he is also called "the Seizer." He is held to be the one who leads forth and generates beings; it is popularly said that he draws out this world and also gathers it back individually.

Brahma is the golden womb, the lord of all creatures. As it is said:

"First, water appeared as a manifestation. Into it a seed was placed. That became a golden egg. From it Brahma was born" — so they say.

Because he was born from that egg, which was in the nature of gold and which served as a womb, he is called the "golden womb" or the "golden birthplace."

Now, these four — Viṣṇu, the Great God (Śiva), Brahmā, and the sun — are not objects of direct perception for any ordinary worldly person, and so they remain hidden. Since knowing hidden objects requires reliance on inference, this is why the text states "of them." And so, regarding these four, their form consists of appearance and shape — that is, their mode of dress — and their conduct consists of their activities and their supremely extraordinary power. Their qualities are distinguished and elevated by their meditative absorption. One should examine and come to know all of these.

O excellent! Those who have entered the teaching of the Sugata — here they should discern: "which one truly possesses these qualities?" And this is the summary meaning: partial, one-sided hatred should be abandoned.

What is said next, speaking from the standpoint of their various visible forms, begins with "Viṣṇu." Viṣṇu, holding his discus, bears weapons such as the discus and others that are beautiful to behold. The terror he inspires is this: Viṣṇu appears in a fearsome manner.

Here is what is told of this. When the gods and the asuras had quarreled over the theft of the nectar of immortality and wished to strike one another, but were unable to impale each other because they had no weapons, a vajra spoke to the gods, saying: "The son of the great sage Pracas, called Dadhīca, has dwelt in austerities for seventy million years, and his bones have become vajra. If you take his bones and fashion them into weapons, you will be able to conquer the three worlds. Ask him for them; with those weapons it will be possible to defeat the asuras." The gods then beseeched that sage and made their request. He, in order to benefit them, had his body reduced to nothing but bones, and gave those bones to them. Thereafter, Viśvakarman fashioned the rib bones into a vajra, which Śakra (Indra) took away. The remaining bones were worked into a staff, and Viṣṇu took that.

Viśvakarman's daughter Reṇukā was led up by the sun. She had taken on a form of gathered radiance, and unable to bear the intensity of that brilliance, she had no desire to play and frolic with her husband. The daughters of the

water pot and other goddesses were likewise unable to endure the brilliance of the sun, and fled and took up residence in their father's house. Their father, Viśvakarman, was displeased, and in his vexation he transformed Reṇukā into the form of a mare and she stayed there, practicing austerities in a mountain valley on Mount Tiṣya.

The sun went out searching for his wife, and when he heard this account he went there, transformed himself into the form of a horse, and mounted her. To prevent another man from impregnating her, he declared his intention, and the sun then revealed his own form and said, "It is from me that these children were conceived." Drawing them out through the nose of his wife, they became the two Aśvins.

When Viśvakarman heard this account, he said to the sun, "If you are able to endure my working on you, I will make your form beautiful; and when it becomes too much to bear, I will let it go at that point when it is good." The sun agreed to this, and Viśvakarman set him on a lathe and worked him down into twelve parts, grinding him down to a disk, and cast what remained on the ground.

From that time onward, the sun became known as "the one whose feet have not been ground down." Viśvakarman then gathered those shavings and fashioned them into a disk, and that disk was named "the blazing one, beautiful to behold." This was given by Viśvakarman to Viṣṇu, and whenever Rāhu stole and drank the nectar of immortality, Viṣṇu would use that disk to cut off Rāhu's head. At that moment too, because on contact with the body of an asura it appeared to blaze brilliantly, it was also called "beautiful to behold."

As for the epithet "the Great God," that means the one who brings happiness, and he is called the Bringer of Happiness because happiness arises from him — because through the Great God (Śiva) the entire world comes to enjoy happiness.

As for the phrase "adorned with a garland of human skulls," this refers to sport and play. It is said that he, rejoicing at being freed from the sin of having harmed a brahmin, dances each day in the great charnel ground of the city known as Ujjayinī, naked, with a thousand arms, before the entire assembly of gods. This is what the tradition recounts.

Now the two asura brothers Sunda and Upasunda had become like a hailstorm of enemies to the gods. In order to destroy them, a divine maiden called

Tilottamā was conjured from a compilation of the individual portions of the gods' own splendor. When she bowed in homage before the gods, Brahmā saw her and, his mind captivated by her form, manifested four faces looking in the four directions, and above these he manifested a fifth head complete with neck. And it is said that when Śiva perceived the lineage from which Brahmā had come and realized that if Śiva were to speak in that lineage's name before the assembly of gods Brahmā would be shamed, Śiva cut off that head with his fingernail.

Because of that, Śiva was tainted by the sin of having injured and harmed a brahmin, and he adopted the following observances: carrying a human skull taken from among the gods, dwelling in charnel grounds, smearing himself with the ashes of cremated bodies, wearing a still-moist elephant hide, making offerings at regular intervals each day, and each day dancing before gods and spirits — and so forth. It is therefore said that he is ornamented and adorned with a garland of fearsome ornaments made of human skulls. That is why the verse uses those words.

"Supremely tranquil" means one who is tranquil in the highest degree.

"Of pre-eminent conduct" means one who possesses the activities of body and so forth — entirely pure and free of fault. This is as the sūtra declares: "The bodily activities of the Tathāgata are utterly pure," and so on.

Therefore, the one endowed with such supremely tranquil conduct is the Blessed One, the Buddha. As it is said:

O Blessed One, your very body reveals the nature of freedom from desire.
From hollow, dry wood no green shoot will sprout.

Should one worship him, or instead worship Viṣṇu, Brahmā, the Great God, and others of that kind, whose conduct resembles that of madmen and who are not at peace? That is a question you yourself may put. Is the censure of these gods aimed merely at their bearing weapons, or is it censure only of things like their dancing and such?

Therefore the verse says "Viṣṇu" and so forth — meaning that through Viṣṇu the lineage known as "the hard-to-fight" and so forth was destroyed. As the account runs: Viṣṇu asked of Subrahmaṇya, "Will you take the eighteen military divisions?"

But when Viṣṇu asked, "Will you take only the god of wealth?" and Subrahmaṇya replied, "I will take the army and its host," Viṣṇu became

enraged at that answer, and having taken the side of the wandering ascetics, he advanced to meet them in battle. Then Arjuna (Siddhasādhya) surveyed everything and spoke: "I am not able to kill the host of my kinsmen. How could I slay those kinsmen for whose sake I desire to obtain the kingdom?" And so he turned back from the fighting, whereupon Viṣṇu said to him:

"You are foolish.

He who kills a man,

and he who is killed —

neither of these two is found to be real;

there is no one slain and no one slaying.

Those of noble lineage and fine conduct,

brāhmaṇas, bulls, and elephants,

dogs and those who eat dog-flesh —

the wise regard them all as equal."

Thus Viṣṇu taught many verses setting out a nihilistic view, of this kind and more. Then, having deceived Arjuna by showing him a variety of forms, Viṣṇu himself took the reins of Arjuna's chariot and spread the battle, and thus brought about the destruction of the eighteen divisions of the host of the hard-to-fight lineage.

A king named Rūpati, together with one division of his army, when the battle was joined, disguised himself in women's clothing, fled, and took refuge in a forest in the Himalayas. The lineage descended from him has been known, down to the present day, by the name "Bod."

The king known as "Joymaker who captured the foal" — he who "strives in his wrath" — his arms were cut off, and twenty-one times over he swept the earth free of the warrior lineage, and at the place called Kurukṣetra he filled five hundred pools, each five leagues across on every side, with the blood of the warrior caste, and offered it as a funerary libation to his deceased ancestors.

A divine daughter named Rambhā, having taken the form of a vulture, roamed by day; and by night she lay with the king named Śatadhanvan. When Viṣṇu heard this, he set a vulture upon that king. The king, in his fear, sought refuge with Arjuna. When Viṣṇu and Arjuna were engaged in fierce battle, Arjuna's arrow stripped the flesh from Viṣṇu's body. Viṣṇu in turn severed Arjuna's head with his discus and seized the vulture. She, having been touched by Viṣṇu's body, was freed from the curse of the sage that had previously turned her into a vulture, and she departed for the celestial realm. Then Śakra (Indra, lord of

the gods) came and poured ambrosia upon his own son Arjuna and revived him.

Now, Bala-deva was the maternal uncle of Śabda-ghoṣa. Someone said to Śabda-ghoṣa: "Since your maternal uncle is bound and confined beneath the earth, what use is your kingdom to you?" To this Śabda-ghoṣa, with the pride of one who declares himself the conqueror of the three earths, entered underground with a great army in order to liberate Bala-deva.

At that time, Viṣṇu was lying asleep upon the coils of the serpent Ananta, and Śrī (Lakṣmī), lamenting in her sorrow, woke him with her cries. Awakened, he blew Śabda-ghoṣa and his retinue like insects a hundred leagues away with a single breath. Then he drew them back with that same breath, reduced them to a thinness like threads, and thought: "This one was granted excellence by Brahmā; therefore I should not kill him," and so let him go. And further, through the device of abducting Sītā, the lineage of Śabda-ghoṣa too was destroyed from the root — and so the account goes on.

As for the Great God (Śiva), he is Maheśvara. His destruction of the Triple City: the asuras dwelling in that Triple City had thrown the three worlds into utter turmoil, and the gods offered their supplication —

Though he was turned back, he refused to be turned back, and in anger he took up his great bow and with a triple-pointed arrow burned the Triple City to ashes. And so it is said to be widely known that the Great God destroyed the Triple City. Thus, because he smashed and demolished the Triple City, he came to be known as the Destroyer of the Triple City. The word "widely known" means: "I heard it from those who proclaim various accounts throughout the world." As for "the Witherer," that is the youth Kārttikeya. Grasping a short, compact, and irresistibly hard spear, he thrust it into a mountain crane, and thereby slew his maternal uncle.

And this is what is told on that account. That crane became the maternal uncle of the Witherer; and when the asura called Kṛttikā inflicted great harm upon the gods, the gods at that time supplicated Śakra (Indra, king of the gods), and he in turn charged the god of desire: "Arrange things so that the Great God, abandoning his austerities, spends what feels like a single day passing through a full thousand divine years in pleasure and delight with Umā, thus keeping him thoroughly befuddled." The gods, meanwhile, fearing that a son of surpassing might would be born from this union and thinking, "He will come and reduce us to his servants," sent the fire god to interrupt the act of

intercourse. The fire god transformed himself into the form of a dove and went there. Upon seeing him, the Great God flew into a rage and poured his semen onto the fire god, who was burned by it and, full of shame, retreated to dwell in the ocean, longing for it, among the reed thickets. The Pleiades too, for the sake of their winter bathing, entered the ocean and became cold on the western side; and when they saw the blazing fire they went toward it, and the warmth of that fire caused conception in them. From that, the child was born in fragments, and when these fragments were placed in a vessel, they became the youth, the Witherer. Each of the Pleiades said in turn, "This one is my son," and "This one is my daughter," and they offered their breasts to him. And to please those mothers, he displayed himself as six-faced. The Great God then, being a man of great prosperity, took him home and performed the birth ceremonies, and the gods carried him to the consecration waters where he was empowered as their military commander.

Even though the asura Kṛttikā waged war for a full thousand divine years, he could not be slain. The Witherer then beseeched Umā: "Give me a flesh-eating spear," and she gave it to him, and with that weapon of the Witherer, the asura Kṛttikā was slain. The remnants of that asura's shattered army, finding no refuge befitting their state, thought: "We will not transgress the word of our maternal uncle," and so they took refuge with his maternal uncle, the crane. The Witherer sent a messenger to the crane, saying: "The custom of kings is that the remnants of an enemy are not to be tolerated. Release the host of the forces of the asura Kṛttikā, my enemy." But the crane, thinking, "Those who have come seeking refuge must not be abandoned," did not release them. As it is said:

Even grass-blades seized upon in sudden desperation —
though all the surrounding grass be cut away entirely,
if they hold fast, or fall together with them,
what need is there to speak of beings possessed of mind?

Thinking then, "In that case they must be taken by force," the Witherer engaged in battle, thrust his spear into the crane, his own maternal uncle, killed him, and seized that army. So it is widely recounted.

In order to show that the Blessed One, the buddha, does not conduct himself in such a manner, the text mentions "buddha" and so forth. The buddha alone is the healer of beings, acting for the welfare of sentient beings; and since he rejoices in the good of others, that very conduct is the conduct of the noble

ones, and because he possesses that very conduct, he is called by that name. In order to show that all misbehavior arises from perverted conceptual thought, the text says "by me" and so forth. The phrase "one to be harmed" means: "This is an enemy, therefore he is one to be harmed — one has acted against the adversary, yet seen no fault in it." Just as Viṣṇu did to Śabdapāpa and others, so too "this one is to be protected" means just as Viṣṇu protected the grey mongoose and others. "This one is to be killed" means "this one is to be slain" — just as the asuras, such as the one seated on a golden throne, were killed. "Of the foremost among gods" refers to those widely renowned as powerful gods, such as Viṣṇu and others. "This is the established custom" means "this is the very action to be done" — that is the sense. The Blessed One, the buddha, has no enemy whatsoever to be slain, for he is endowed with great compassion. He has no one to be deceived either, for he has no rival who could compete with him through stratagems of deceit, since he acts with singular delight in the welfare of others, establishing all beings of the three worlds without exception in perfect excellence. If one asks what it is that the buddha achieves, the answer is: what is truly good is unmistakably and perfectly wholesome — that is to say, nirvāṇa; and high attainment means distinguished and excellent worldly prosperity; and he brings about the happiness that consists of both of these, not a merely partial benefit — he bestows benefit through both and leads beings into both, and thus he is said to bestow benefit in a uniquely complete way. In order to show that the conduct of others is not like this, the text mentions "Viṣṇu" and so forth.

The name Viṣṇu is one that generates the stains of faults such as attachment and the rest. Calling upon Brahmā and others as witnesses out of fear of worldly cursing, and having been bound by an oath through the touch of Sitāmela, he was told by his various companions: "Give it up." For those who fear worldly curses, doubt arises at every step; those who are extremely timid and restrained grow weary even of prosperity. So it is told. At the time when, though bound by oath through the touch of Sitāmela, he did not become chaste, at that very time he fell to the ground in supplication and entered in. Rāmaṇa grew enraged, took up his sword, and entered to kill him even with the merest scratch. Brahmā then turned him back, saying: "Do not harm this one who has become a pillar of the world." In one account, when the garuḍa (Skt. garuḍa) and Viṣṇu were fighting, the garuḍa emerged victorious, and Viṣṇu said: "Your conquest of the opponent pleases me — ask a boon of me." The garuḍa replied: "Since I have defeated you, why should I ask a boon of

you?" Viṣṇu said: "Then I will ask a boon of you — grant it. Let you yourself become my mount." And thereupon the garuḍa became his mount. Viṣṇu then descended into a country and was dwelling there, taking pleasure in just that place.

When the activities of the gods had fallen into decline, the gods petitioned Brahmā on that account. At that time Brahmā entered the guise of a wretched-looking figure and was sent there, and in a secluded place he took counsel together with Rāmaṇa. Rāmaṇa stationed his younger brother at the gate with a sword, saying: "Allow no one whatsoever the opportunity to enter. Whoever tries to enter, I shall have him killed." As it happened, a great sage came to that wretched place, and when he tried to enter, the gatekeeper said: "If I do not let him in, I will destroy your entire lineage without exception." Rāmaṇa's younger brother then thought to himself: "It is better for me to die than for the entire lineage to be destroyed — that would be wrong," and so he went inside and reported this to Rāmaṇa. Thereupon Rāmaṇa, in order to reinforce the oath that had been sworn, took up a sword and set about killing the sage. A brahmin then said: "Killing a cuckoo is the same as killing a person, so rather than kill him, drive him away from your own land." And so he was duly expelled. That one, unable to reach Rāmaṇa, went to another quarter and cast himself into fire. When news of this reached him, Rāmaṇa was filled with grief, and it is said that he drowned himself in the Ganges along with the people of a city called "Inviolable River," ending his life in the water.

The verse then says:

Fish and turtle and boar,
the man-lion, the dwarf,
and Rāmaṇa the delighter, the dark one,
the buddha, Kalki — these ten.

The ten descents of Viṣṇu that this verse recounts are now to be explained in this context.

When this great earth became entirely flooded with water, Viṣṇu, in order to benefit beings, transformed his own body into a turtle and sank into the water, whereupon the four Vedas entered beneath the earth. Then the gods petitioned Viṣṇu on their account, and taking on the form of a fish he retrieved them and gave them to the gods. When the earth-deity was crushed under the unbearably heavy burden of the great earth and petitioned the gods saying that he could not bear this load, Viṣṇu transformed into a turtle and lifted that

burden. Likewise, Viṣṇu took the form of a boar, sank beneath the great earth, and with his tusks lifted it up from below.

One called "Golden Protector of Beings" practised austerities for seven hundred thousand years and attained the supreme, whereupon he was granted a boon: "May you not perish by day or by night, indoors or outdoors, on earth or in the sky, below or above; and likewise may you not be slain by weapons, clubs, humans, gods, or animals." After some time, there was a great assembly gathered in a circle extending five leagues, and among them it was reported that someone was standing at the king's gate whose upper half had the form of a human and whose lower half had the form of a lion. The Golden Protector of Beings together with his retinue was amazed and went out to fight, and so they approached for battle. Then, at the boundary between day and night, the figure took the threshold of the gate, placed it on his knee, and tore open the breast of the Golden Protector of Beings with his claws, killing him.

Likewise, when the Mighty One (Bali) was performing the horse-sacrifice, Viṣṇu transformed into the form of a dwarf, went about begging, and when alms were given asked for as much land as three paces would cover. By the power of his magical might he pressed down the three worlds, covering them with his three strides. Finding no place to set his third step, he bound the Mighty One, who to this day still dwells beneath the earth.

Thereafter the court poets composed the verse:

The patron, the Mighty One, gave the great earth to Viṣṇu the mendicant
at the time of the horse-sacrifice —
and the fruit he obtained was to be bound.
Who would here aspire to the deed of giving?

Such, indeed, is what was spoken. Likewise, Rāmaṇa, dwelling on the side of the powerful and ill-omened quarter, dragged the earth with a plough and made it uneven, so that springs and wells and the like came to exist.

Nandana is the son of king Rāmaṇa of the ten chariots. Here the tale of king Rāmaṇa is to be told. Nandana — that is, the sage Jāmadagni (Nandana-Śatru by name), the son of Agni — his tale also is to be joined here.

Since Rāmaṇa slew an incalculable number of rākṣasas, in order to purify that sin, people of the world proclaim: "In this age of strife he will appear in the form of Viṣṇu the buddha." As for one called Kalki, it is heard thus: a son

named Kalki, born of the brahmin called Yaśas, will appear last, and it is said that from that point the age will turn.

Viṣṇu then spoke:

Among the suns, I am Viṣṇu.

Among the stars, I am the luminous moon.

Among the winds, I am the bearer of rays.

Among those that shine, I am the sun.

Among the Vedas, I am sacred verse.

Among the gods, I am Śakra.

Among the senses, I am mind.

Among the elements, I am consciousness.

I am both the pleasant and the fierce.

Among rākṣasas and yakṣas, I am the lord of wealth.

Among the gods of wealth, I am the fire god.

Among mountains, I am Mount Meru.

Among syllables, I am the letter A —

and so forth. Thus it is established that he conducts himself in a manner resembling the behaviour of one who is mad. He behaves exactly as one afflicted by madness behaves, and his words too are presented in that same fashion.

Likewise, whatever is said by the Great God (Śiva) is also presented as behaviour resembling that of a madman. That is: one who plays the lute and sings, who makes others glad and dances — such a person will attain happiness; one who goes about naked will attain prosperity; and one should present oneself as though one's conduct were that of laughter and sport — such is what the Great God is said to have declared.

Likewise too, in order to purify the sin of having severed the head of the great Brahmā, which arose from the cause of the highest ḍākinī, he undertook the ascetic vow of carrying a human skull. And likewise, in order to arouse the amorous joy of the wives of the sages, while those sages were dwelling in the forest of thorn-trees and their wives had gone outside to gather firewood and the like, the Great God raised his characteristic mark and entered that place, and stirred the minds of the great sages' wives and daughters. When those sages returned in the evening and heard this account, they were enraged and cursed him, causing his characteristic mark to fall to the ground. The Great God then assumed the form of an elephant and entered the dense thickets of

the śāla forest. People heard that account and went to the great sages and retrieved that mark. The sages honoured one another, and the Great God was restored to his mark. Thereafter, while he was sporting and playing together with Umā, due to the intervention of an obstacle-maker, his seed fell upon the ground; and as it made a crying sound, Umā placed an elephant's head upon it, and from that was born Vināyaka.

At another time, when the child was being nourished with milk and so forth, because the elephant delighted in the smell and because he had previously been a gandharva, he desired to drink wine; and the Great God permitted this, saying: "The lord of creatures does no harm, and therefore this is an emanation" — and he gave his approval.

Likewise, a blind asura, having assumed the form of the Great God, wished to engage in union with Umā, and approached her —

But when she saw a mole on the side of his chest, she did not desire him. When the Great God (Śiva) heard this account, he took up his trident, entered into battle, and hurled it at the asura. From the body of the blind asura, as many drops of blood as fell, that many new asuras arose and came forward to fight. For that purpose, the gods conjured eight goddesses beginning with Cāmuṇḍī, and as they descended through the air they drank the blood so that not a single drop fell to the earth, and in this way they slew him.

Likewise, the Great God caught sight of the god Nandīśvara after a long time and said to him: "Where have you been?" He replied: "I composed a treatise with proper reasoning." The Great God said: "Bring it here." When he brought it, the Great God flew into a rage, cut it into two pieces, and cast it into the fire at the mouth of the ocean. Nandīśvara then said: "From the marks on your fingernails I can see the sign of a brahmin-slayer" — referring to his having cut off the head of Brahmā and taken up the observance of the skull-bearer — and at this the Great God was pleased. He retrieved the treatise from the ocean's fire and divided it into two parts: a treatise on astrology, and one called "The Oceanic," teaching the characteristics of women, men, palmistry, and so forth. Such are their defining marks — they are incoherent, like the ravings of a madman.

The speech of the Tathāgata, by contrast, eliminates all faults without exception and brings peace. Of this it has been said:

A medicine supremely beneficial for the sickness of affliction,
A supreme lamp that dispels the darkness of total bewilderment —

Since it opens the eye that gives rise to the wisdom of suchness,
Listen to the vast speech of the buddhas.

Taming body and the rest, it clears away the three faults,
Liberates from the three realms, and achieves the wisdom of the three times;
Pacifies the three lower destinies and gains the three awakenings.
Hearing and all else: it holds the three supreme stages from the very
beginning.

There is no other teaching like this for one so greatly fortunate.
Therefore, having made offering to the speech of the Sage,
Listen to it with the utmost reverence.

And so it is said, and more.

Therefore: carefully understand and examine which one is rightly worthy of the highest regard as the teacher who teaches peace and nirvāṇa — this is the import of "examine and declare who is great," or simply "listen." The words beginning with "who" are spoken in order to make clear through another's words that the Blessed One himself is worthy of being the great teacher. One such as the Great God, who strives to cause harm to others, is devoid of love and has abandoned compassion — for one who possesses compassion does not act to harm others.

Furthermore, the Blessed One the buddha is one to whom throngs of living beings throughout all the destinies have gone for refuge, who has become the ground of refuge, and who has given his word: "I shall be your support and your refuge from harm" — satisfying them with words such as "Fear not."

If it be objected that even though one has pledged to benefit others, one may fail to do so through the power of mental afflictions such as attachment, then the text speaks to this with the words "one endowed with attachment" and so forth: in that case, between one who possesses attachment and one who is free from attachment, examine and reflect carefully, and then declare which of the two is worthy of being worshipped and honored here.

Therefore it is made perfectly clear that it is precisely one who possesses compassion and is free from attachment who alone is worthy of worship and veneration. This is the meaning of that statement.

If it is objected that there are those who strive with the aim of harming others, the text addresses this by citing Śakra (Indra, king of the gods) and the rest.

Śakra means "mighty," because he is mighty enough to slay his enemies; and it should be understood that he is indeed one who harms others. Moreover, he bears the vajra — yet those who are compassionate do not take up weapons in order to slay others. The cause from which the vajra arose has already been explained. "Powerful" means of great strength. "Bearing the plow-blade" means bearing the plow-blade as a weapon.

Now, it is well known that on account of the causes arising from the theft of the nectar of immortality, a great war broke out between the gods and the asuras. At that time Śakra bore the vajra, the Dryer bore a short spear, and the Powerful One bore the plow-blade. As for the Powerful One, he is held to be an emanation of Nāgarāja Vasudhara (the nāga king who upholds the great earth), and the plow is said to serve his vast purpose. As for Viṣṇu (Viṣṇu, the wheel-bearing god), bearing the weapon of the wheel — the manner in which the wheel arose has already been explained.

The Dryer is also known as Kārttikeya and as the Six-Faced One, these being synonymous names. As for the line "bearing the short spear": the story goes as follows. The asura Māhī performed austerities for five hundred divine years and thereby gratified the Great God (Śiva), and from him obtained a short spear for the purpose of slaying men. By means of this, Māhī caused both gods and men to be utterly overcome. The gods then petitioned Umā, saying: "Though you are a woman, this being has obtained a weapon to slay men, and because of this we are in grave danger — strive therefore to render it powerless." Umā then gratified the Great God through austerities and obtained a three-pronged spear. Battle was joined, and when Māhī was pierced by the three-pronged spear, from every drop of blood that fell from the body of the asura Māhī there arose that many asuras of the same name. And from the drops of sweat that fell to the ground from the brow of Umā, there arose beings of terrifyingly fierce aspect who fed on flesh; these consumed in mid-air the very drops of blood, and thus the asura was slain. The short spear was then obtained, and the Dryer took it up and gave it to the Dryer — meaning the short spear passed to Skanda. As for the Great God, he is the wrathful Great God, of whom it is said:

He burns like sharp fire,
he feeds upon the sacrificial post that is bright,
he consumes flesh and bones and blood and such —
thus is he called the Wrathful One.

As for "bearing the three-pronged weapon": it is explained that the three-pronged weapon forged from the bone of the sage Dadhīca (Dadhīca, a great sage) by Viśvakarman (the craftsman of the gods) was given to the Great God by the gods. Others say: at the time when the triple city was being burned, the gods petitioned the Great God; and when he took up his weapon, the gods' sages brought the bone of Dadhīca, the nāgas brought the skull of the tortoise that had served as the base of the Mandara mountain, and men brought the vajra. Then Viśvakarman fashioned these three into a three-pronged weapon and gave it to the Great God — so it is said. "Dwelling in charnel grounds" means that the wrathful Great God resides in charnel grounds.

With respect to all the gods without exception, the text speaks of "these" and so forth. "These" refers to Śakra and the rest. What sort of beings are they? Because they arise from ignorance, they are called childish — and this is an expression of censure, O monks,

because of speaking wrongly and engaging in actions of wrong conduct, they are called childish — so it was declared. What else are they like? They are without compassion — this is the meaning of "lacking compassion and being vicious." Those who are not vicious and contrary do not destroy others. Being vicious in that way, they bear various weapons; that is, they carry many weapons of different kinds and varied forms. And these gods are accompanied by suffering and the rest. "Suffering" means that which immediately afflicts and torments both body and mind. "Fear" means that, dreading the suffering of the future, the mind trembles and one becomes dispirited in oneself — and by these two one is menaced and tormented nearby. Thus those who are free of the afflictions of suffering and fear have no need to carry weapons in order to harm others.

If it be objected that they carry weapons not to kill but only to intimidate others — therefore the text says "always" and the rest: they constantly and continuously strive to destroy and slay embodied beings and living creatures, and so they carry weapons. As for such beings, what wise person, endowed with wisdom and discerning the distinction between virtue and fault, would bow down and pay homage to them? This shows that they are not worthy of veneration.

In order to demonstrate that the Blessed One himself is worthy of worship precisely because he is free of the faults just described, the text says "that one

who" and so forth. The three-pronged weapon is carried in order to destroy enemies. Likewise, out of desire-laden attachment, one keeps a wife at one's side — that is, one has her rest at one's flank. If it be objected that there is no fault in carrying girls at one's side, the reply is: the Blessed One does not have a wife at his side in the manner of the Great God (Śiva), accompanied by the desire of sensual longing; nor does he carry a discus in the manner of Viṣṇu (Kṣobhya); nor does he carry a short noose in the manner of the Witherer; nor does he destroy enemies with a vajra and carry weapons in the manner of Śakra (Indra); nor does he carry a plough in the manner of Subalīn. Why does he not carry these weapons? Because he is completely liberated from the afflictions — that is to say, he is decisively freed and utterly relinquished from the host of afflictions such as attachment and the rest.

"The wise one strives to benefit others" — this means striving to accomplish the welfare of others, and the meaning is that he is endowed with great compassion. "A refuge" means one worthy of going to for refuge. A refuge for whom? For those of the world. Why is he worthy of refuge? Because he is endowed with excellent wisdom and excellent relinquishment, one may infer that he has become the Teacher of the three realms of existence and is worthy of refuge. Who is this? A sage — the great sage, the Buddha, the Blessed One. "Here, for this one" means: I go for refuge to the Buddha, the Blessed One, here. And to go for refuge relying upon him means, in the sense that sins and non-virtuous things are broken apart and dispersed, he is a refuge. In order to make clear that since faults exist in others but the Blessed One has no faults, therefore you yourself are the refuge — the text mentions "the Great God" and the rest: the Great God grasps and takes a wife, being under the power of the desire of sensual longing. What kind of Great God? One who has abandoned shame — that is, one who through attachment is devoid of shame. And indeed:

Desire destroys shame,

Grief makes one unstable,

Joy makes one lose one's body,

And pride utterly destroys

All virtuous qualities.

As for "the Fierce One" — he is one whose very nature is to harm life, characterized by behavior such as slaying and attacking through aversion. The meaning is that the Great God (Śiva), possessed of these faults, takes and holds a wife.

Viṣṇu is exceedingly savage: even toward people who have become objects of compassion, there is no appeasing or pacifying him — as shown by his entering upon the slaughter of Lakṣmaṇa and others. As for "good deeds being wasted" — the Mighty One, even when three worlds were given as a gift, saw to it that they were bound. To bind and confine someone who does great benefit is unreasonable.

The Parcher slew his own kinsman. There is a mountain known as Krauñca, and that mountain was his maternal uncle; he slew it — and furthermore, it is said to have been slain not by another's hand but by his own.

The Ascetic-Averter is the goddess Umā. She is wrathful and savage. Although the female sex is for the most part endowed with affection, Umā is not like that. Why? Because the great asura (Skt. asura) known as Māheśa is her slayer. The Mātṛkās too are cruel and savage. Why? Because they feed on and consume human flesh and fat. And who are those Mātṛkās? They are Brāhmī, Drāgmā, Vaiṣṇavī, Kaumārī, Aindrī, Kauberī, Vārāhī, and Cāmuṇḍā — these eight are called the Mātṛkās.

The Misleader is the lord of obstacles, the master of hosts (Gaṇapati). He is greatly addicted to wine — he craves liquor. What was said about him has been stated already.

"The Possessor of Ten Powers" — this refers to the Buddha. In him, not even the slightest trace of the vast range of faults belonging to the Great God and the rest is to be found — not even a particle of any such fault — for he has abandoned all afflictions together with their habitual tendencies. This is the meaning.

If one objects, "You say this merely because you are biased toward one side" — that is precisely why the text states "That Blessed One" and so forth. The Blessed One, the Buddha, is not my kinsman or relative, nor are the Great God and the others my enemies. In the same way, the conduct of all of these, from the Great God to the Possessor of Ten Powers, I have not witnessed directly with my own eyes. Nevertheless, having heard separately the various texts that describe the distinctions in their words and distinctions in their conduct, I have taken refuge in and relied upon the Blessed One, the Buddha, and have turned away from the others. Why? Because the Buddha is endowed with supremely excellent qualities, and therefore, out of faith and delight in him, and for that reason, I rely upon and abide in his teaching.

In order to make clear that very subject matter thus undertaken, the text mentions "the Sugata" and so forth. Here, the Sugata is not my kinsman, nor are the tīrthikas who have entered other paths — those who eat burnt offerings and so forth — my enemies. Likewise, the Tathāgata did not grant me wealth or benefit me through his speech, nor did those who eat burnt offerings or the one-legged seer steal any of my wealth or possessions.

Now, "one who eats burnt offerings" refers to someone who eats oblations and practices austerities, and through this obtains the supernatural attainment of observance. Thus it was the eater of burnt offerings who composed the foundational texts of the tīrthika school of the outcasts, and it was the one-legged seer who composed the texts of the rationalist school. As for "one-legged" — this refers to a seer whom the Great God had placed there to guard Umā, and who, because of his extremely handsome form, caused Umā to become attached to him —

— he sat there upright, displaying signs of attachment. The seer then looked away. She remained there, and when she too looked away from his glance, this went on until he fixed his eyes on the two legs of the seer. When that story reached the ears of the Great God (Śiva), he was pleased, and he bestowed a supreme gift upon the seer, saying, "May you become the teacher who composes the foundational texts of the rationalist school." The word "and so forth" is to be taken as encompassing other seers, whether wandering ascetics or those of tawny robes, and the like.

Now, someone might think: "If that is how things stand, why do you dwell in a partisan position?" To address that, the text continues with the words "Nevertheless, and so forth." Even though the Blessed One is not an enemy or a friend or anything of that sort, the Blessed One the buddha is in fact a buddha because he is endowed with consummate primordial wisdom; he is the Blessed One because he has abandoned the subtlest traces of the afflictions together with their habitual tendencies; and he acts solely for the benefit of all beings because he is endowed with great compassion that works to accomplish the needs of sentient beings. Thus, because he is endowed with these three qualities, the speech of the Blessed One the buddha is stainless — it is a philosophical conclusion entirely free of all fault, and in the same way it also dispels all defilements; indeed, this very speech has the capacity to dispel and destroy every defilement of the afflictions, for the mere hearing of it eradicates all the latent tendencies of the afflictions. As for "I have faith in him" — this means that I myself have faith and conviction in the speech of the

sovereign among sages.

In order to make clear that one truly has conviction and faith in the Sugata, the text states the words beginning with "whoever." In that passage, "always" means "continuously." "Benefit" means the welfare of others, and because he possesses a disposition of delight and willingness in this, he desires to attain a distinction that transcends the worldly. In the same way, because he always and continually brings appropriate benefit to beings through the distinctive excellences of worldly happiness, whatever must be done so that the sufferings stirred by the afflictions are pacified — the Blessed One does that. And for whom does he do it? For whatever being is tormented, oppressed, and crushed by sufferings of many kinds — him the Blessed One causes to be at ease. Likewise, the Teacher who knows all objects of knowledge — conditioned and unconditioned, past, present, and future — as clearly as though they were placed in the palm of the hand: that Teacher is worthy of being an object of faith. Being one of incomparable discipline who possesses a disposition of constant delight in benefit and so forth — one who has within himself the cause by which there is none other in all three realms equal to him — in him, too, I myself have come to have faith. Scholars endowed with faith are not fit to rely on a wrong path.

Because the Blessed One is endowed with such qualities as delight in benefit and so forth, he is a great field of merit — and to demonstrate this, the text goes on to say "from the heart" and so forth. For even though one may have an excellent intention with faith, reverence, and the like, one may lack continuous engagement, and so the text asks, "Does one have faith from the heart?" And even though one may continuously lack engagement, when one does make offerings to him, it is done "as joyfully as one can" — meaning that one engages after roughly ten years have passed, or after some twenty years, or that one engages without particular occasion; or alternatively, when the right assembly and conditions are present one practices, and when they are not present one does not.

"Or is it with uncertainty?" — This means: if there is merit, that is excellent; but even if there is not, no great purpose of mine is lost. There is the saying:

Let others in this world live in doubt;
the wise should abandon the unwholesome.
If merit does not exist, what harm is done?
If it does, the speech of those who deny it is defeated.

And so on in the manner stated. "Or also for the sake of others" means: thinking "If I do this practice and another does not, that one will incur a great falling away and great blame," one engages on that account.

In this way, with any of these four motivations, if a person pays homage to you, the Lord of Sages (Śākyamuni), that person will obtain the excellent happiness of divine prosperity. How much more, then, is it needless to ask about one who engages in practice with an excellent intention and conduct that is accompanied by faith and the rest? That is the meaning here.

"Moon of the Lord of Sages" — because he is supremely tranquil and brings deep satisfaction, he is like the moon, and thus he is called the Moon of the Lord of Sages. Just as the hungry, upon encountering food, or the thirsty, upon encountering drink, are relieved of hunger and thirst, so too he causes one to obtain excellence.

Those devoted to Viṣṇu say that their own object of devotion is the very one spoken of here. To refute those who say "I have heard this teaching from ancient tales — from old stories of the wind," the text states "In ancient times" and so forth. The very buddha venerated by the three worlds is none other than Viṣṇu — this they claim because the text previously states "A fish, a turtle, a boar, and so on." But this is not so. Foolish and dull-witted people fail to understand that it is the Blessed One, the Buddha, who in the world of the three grounds (tridhātu) taught suchness and bestowed benefit upon all beings. A buddha, furthermore, appears only once every hundred times — only a handful of times throughout an immensity of cosmic ages. As it is said:

In ten billion ten million eons,
and in ten billion hundred million more,
if even the name of a buddha is not heard,
what need is there to speak of seeing one?

If it is objected that this Viṣṇu appears in an age of strife and therefore we do not venerate him, to that objection the text answers with "At that time" and so forth.

"Attachment" means clinging and fixation upon jewels and the like. "Aversion" is the mind that intends harm to another; "those who harbor it" means those who bear hatred toward enemies. Thus it was through the distinction between those who consumed the ambrosia and those who did not — that is, through attachment and aversion — that these two names, gods (deva) and asuras, came to arise from the time of the churning of the great ocean of milk onward.

For this is what has been heard: at the bidding of Brahmā, the gods gathered on one side and the asuras gathered on the other side. With Viṣṇu grasping from atop Mount Mandara, and the nāga king Vāsuki serving as the churning rope, the great ocean of milk was churned, with a tortoise providing support from below.

Then there arose from it a terrifying dark male figure made of piled venom, called Kālakūṭa. When Viṣṇu was about to swallow it, he lost consciousness, fell to the ground, and lay there unable to speak. Thereupon the Great God (Śiva) drew it from him and held it at his throat. This caused Śiva's throat to become blue.

Then the moon arose. The Great God took it and placed it upon his head.

Then there arose from it the one called Śrī, the goddess of fortune. She took Viṣṇu as her own and united with him. After her came the horse-necked vessel and the all-gathering tree, and these were taken as was fitting by Śakra (Indra) and the other gods.

Then there appeared a woman of surpassing loveliness. When asked who she was, she replied, "I am Surā, the spirit of wine. Whoever drinks me will undergo transformations such as intoxication, unconsciousness, and arrogance." The asuras, being afraid, did not drink her, and from that they came to be called asuras, those who do not drink. The gods drank her, and from that they came to be called suras, the drinkers.

When the nectar of immortality arose, eight great vessels full of it were carried off by the asuras. The gods were utterly dismayed, and at that point Viṣṇu transformed himself into a woman of great allure and surpassing beauty and went toward them. Śakra, meanwhile, remained seated in the sky in an invisible form. The asuras, thinking, "This is our woman," set her as the guardian of the nectar. They themselves went to bathe, for a Dharma treatise has said:

Impurity spreads when one is unwashed,
therefore one should not eat before bathing.

For this reason they went off to bathe. At that moment Viṣṇu and Śakra stole the nectar and carried it away to Śakra's palace. When the asuras returned after bathing and did not find the nectar, they searched diligently for it, and upon hearing that the gods had taken it, they thought: "The gods go above, so it cannot be we asuras — this must be true." Meanwhile the gods assembled to

enjoy the nectar. Rāhu (the eclipse-seizer) transformed himself into the guise of a god, joined them, and obtained a share of the nectar. The sun saw him and said to Viṣṇu, "This one is Rāhu!" Thereupon Viṣṇu severed his head with the discus. Yet because Rāhu had enjoyed and tasted the nectar, his head lives on even to this day, while the remainder of his body perished. From that time Rāhu harbored enmity toward the sun, and so it is told that whenever he covers and eclipses the orb of the sun, it is on account of that hatred.

Now the story of how the gods and asuras came to rob one another of their jewels shall be told. King Prasena possessed a jewel called Syamantaka. Viṣṇu requested it, but Prasena would not give it. Viṣṇu therefore went to war against him with an army of nineteen divisions. Prasena, by merely calling to mind the power of the jewel, had an army of twenty divisions, mighty and capable of overwhelming the enemy. He took to the field and prevailed over Viṣṇu, and they parted. On another occasion King Prasena went out hunting and was killed by a lion. The lord of bears, one named Jāmbavān, saw the jewel in the lion's belly, killed the lion, and carried the jewel away. The rumor arose that Viṣṇu had killed King Prasena for the sake of the jewel, though this was not true. Viṣṇu, in order to clear his name, sent out a party including gods to search. They discovered a young woman weeping in a cave. In order to comfort her mother, the messenger recited:

Prasena was slain by a lion,
the lion was slain by Jāmbavān.
O fair young maiden, this Syamantaka —
give it to one such as this.

Hearing these words being repeated, and wishing to take the jewel back, Viṣṇu himself was sent as a messenger.

That messenger, being very intelligent and unimpeded in obtaining what he sought, was taken up by Jāmbavan's daughter on behalf of Viṣṇu. The lord of the bears then agreed, saying, "I will give you the girl and the jewel as well." Viṣṇu became angry and said, "What use is the girl? Fight him, kill him, and strip him of them." Those accompanying the gods said:

Casting aside arrogance and contempt,
and likewise shame and radiant dignity,
one should steadily accomplish one's own aim —
it is pointless to lament the ruin of one's own purpose.

Hearing these words, he took heed and obtained everything. Now, Jāmbavan's son is an asura who roams about in the form of a bear, and he it was who plundered that jewel when it existed. As for the jewel of the gods, it is the pārijāta tree and the like — that too was plundered from Śakra (Indra). This should be composed in accordance with the story as it is celebrated in the poetry on the plundering of jewels.

This intelligence of attachment and clinging — because it belongs to one who is attached — is the intelligence of attachment. Through it, that one acted with malicious deceit to defraud others, and through it, lands were seized. At first, the Powerful One had brought all lands under his sway; then the intelligence of attachment arose, with the thought of plundering them further. At the time when he transformed into the form of a dwarf and seized the earth, he became a being whose very nature was that of a plunderer. And though he abided bound by the fetters of attachment and the rest of the afflictions and was not freed, foolish people lacking wisdom worship him with offerings of flowers and the like, and bow down to him.

The Blessed One, the Buddha himself, though completely liberated from the entire host of latent tendencies, is rarely bowed to by most people. The Blessed One, the Buddha, is fully liberated from the mass of afflictions, has thoroughly understood the meaning of all things without exception, and is serene and purified both outwardly and inwardly — and yet they do not bow to him. Why is this? The text says: because of delusion — that is, covered by the darkness of not-knowing, they do not bow down due to their particular ignorance.

Furthermore, in order to show that the Blessed One, the Buddha himself, is the supreme field of merit, while others are not so, the text says "this earth" and so on. The great earth, encompassed on all sides like a girdle by the assembly of the four oceans residing to the east and in the other directions, possessing many qualities, is like a heavy load — because it is difficult to lift, it lies massively heavy; and because it rests in a state of extreme evenness, it lies as though supremely stable. Such an earth, heavy and thus settled, was indeed given by the Powerful One to Viṣṇu — yet the fruit of that act, through the suffering of being bound and imprisoned in a dungeon beneath the earth, was the attainment of a state of misery. Thus he attained and experienced a condition overwhelmed by affliction and suffering.

Here the distinction is this: by merely offering a handful of earth's dust to Śākyamuni, the Blessed One, the Sage and Buddha, one came to be known as King Aśoka. This refers to when the Blessed One had gone to Rājagṛha for alms, and a young boy named Jaya, upon seeing him, was filled with deep faith and offered him a handful of dust from the roadway. The Blessed One then declared: "When one hundred years have passed after my complete passing into nirvāṇa, this boy will become a wheel-turning king by the name of Aśoka."

As for the young boy Vijaya, because he rejoiced in the Victorious One, the prophecy was declared that he would become the chief minister of that king, known by the name Chariot-Hidden.

As for the kind of domain that was obtained through this: all the land pervaded by the radiance of a complete lunar disk was obtained without remainder, and moreover this land was good — free from untimely death, famine, epidemic, and such harms.

Thus these two cases — the sacred field and what is not a sacred field — teach that merit arises precisely from that distinction.

Someone might think: "You speak as you do merely because you are partisan." To that end the words "I, for my part" and so forth were spoken. The meaning is this: I do not hold the side of the Buddha without reason, or with some fault as my reason, and I am not partisan. Nor do I bear hatred toward or wish harm upon the non-Buddhist teachers (tīrthikas) — the brahmins, the wanderers in ochre robes, and others. Rather, just as the sun abides impartially everywhere without reason or partiality, one must proceed in the same way universally. Therefore, whoever's words are endowed with valid reasoning and can withstand the scrutiny of valid cognition — that very one is to be accepted as the Teacher, and the noble ones take refuge in that very one alone. This is the meaning.

All beings of this world are unworthy of refuge, because they are not free from attachment, and because they are wholly attended by the demons of mental affliction — like a house inhabited by a rākṣasa of Brahmā. This is the view of those who are possessed of discernment. Therefore the words "And so it is thus" and so forth were stated. Among these four, it is certain that some one has become omniscient, and not all of them have reached the ultimate. Just as among luminous things the sun is supreme, and among small bodies of water the ocean is supreme, and among mountains Mount Meru is supreme — so among those with intelligence, the omniscient one is supremely distinguished,

while others do not know all that is to be known. In the same way, that one's teaching benefits beings in every respect, and his system of teaching is utterly vast. The very teaching comprising eighty-four thousand aggregates of Dharma and so forth — that is what the intelligent person should seek. With what kind of intelligence, one asks? It should be sought with the eye of subtle intelligence, for intelligence itself is the eye that perceives the subtle. Having searched and examined with that eye, one should then rely on it. As for others — those who are not omniscient, who are skilled in sophistry and cause harm to sentient beings — what is the use of relying on them and taking them as the Teacher? What purpose does it serve? There is not a single purpose of benefit. This is the meaning.

Then what is it, by relying on which, that all purposes will be accomplished? To that end the words "And here, that which" and so forth were stated. A Teacher in whom there is not the totality of all faults of mental affliction along with their habitual tendencies, and in whom there is the totality of all qualities such as moral discipline, meditative absorption, and so forth, completely and in all respects — that one alone is my Teacher, and that one alone is the refuge of all beings without exception, and no other. I do not say this merely out of inability to bear the name, but otherwise there is a substantive fault in that claim.

Now this is what it teaches: if someone argues that the Great God (Śiva) and Viṣṇu are free from the faults described and are therefore the Teacher, that argument is reasonable; but since Brahmā is not endowed with any of those faults, it follows that Brahmā is the fitting Teacher of all the earth. Or again, if it is said that this one too has faults, then let those faults be stated. They are to be articulated as follows:

In truth, he is not even free from attachment in the desire realm, and so how could one say that none of these stains of fault exist in him? Those very faults exist in him a hundredfold. These two gods and Brahmā are spoken of as being equal in this regard. It is well known that when Brahmā took the goddess Umā as his bride and circled around her, upon seeing her surpassing form he lost his composure, fell into a swoon, and his semen was released. Then, shamed by this, he was kicked and shattered into many hundreds of fragments, and from those fragments were born eighty thousand sages called Loving Children. It is also told that from what Brahmā had given as the highest gift, two brothers named Sundha and Upasundha caused terrible harm throughout the three worlds, and that to destroy them, all the gods gathered the radiant

splendor of their own bodies and projected forth a supreme gem-drop called Tikilemakma. When she bowed before Brahmā, he, overcome by desire for her, manifested four faces in all four directions, and the Great God (Śiva) severed the head that faced upward — and so on and so forth, many such degraded deeds are recounted. Further faults arise even from the implications of his name. And again, he is shown to be a teacher of falsehood, as when he says, "You all are my emanations," and so on — these words and others like them are heard to contain many faults. But in the teaching of the Blessed One there is not even a trace of any such stain of fault.

And on this it is said:

The god who declares, "I will rescue the faithful from poverty,
yet am unable to do so in life —
after death I shall protect them" —
that god speaks false words.

One who says "if touched by fire one does not burn,
but if remembered it burns" —
if that were truly so,
then both fire and memory would be alike.

If the Blessed One were like that,
he would not teach the nature of karma.
As the sun illuminates the ground,
he makes clear the nature of beings.

The world does not experience results it has not made.
One accumulates karma through one's own afflictions.
Virtue and non-virtue, whether wished for or not,
are like seeds that produce their fruit.

Knowing all phenomena completely,
all faults utterly exhausted,
bringing benefit to every sentient being —
all these are the Tathāgata.

Thus these things are spoken. And to teach this very meaning more extensively, the words beginning with "in whom" are given. "Immeasurable" means without limit. "Compassionate" means endowed with great compassion. By virtue of that, with the pure divine eye he gazes without cease upon the entire world — as has been said, "With the eye of a buddha he gazes

upon the worlds six times, three times by day and three times by night." Being thus endowed with great compassion, he rescues these beings from suffering, and as he is the supreme refuge and support, one goes to him for refuge and relies upon him.

To dedicate that praise just described, the words beginning with "lotus" are given. Because the Blessed One the buddha is endowed with supremely excellent bodily qualities, he has eyes as beautiful as an open blue lotus in full bloom, long and lovely in their extent. This is what that epithet means, for his eyes are the supreme excellence among the faculties of the body of form. This mention of the characteristic of his eyes is given merely as an illustration, for he is in truth the dwelling place of all qualities without exception.

Just as the ocean is the support and resting place into which many thousands of rivers flow, so the Blessed One is the ground and basis from which arise the many hundreds and thousands of rivers of laudatory praise of his qualities. To him who has become such a place of praise, and having thus offered praise and expressed adoration in this way — from that praise in words, one now declares: "By whatever root of virtue I have cultivated and produced, however small it may be, by this root of virtue may all sentient beings come to be endowed with unsurpassed happiness." The definite excellence here is happiness that is beyond reproach, and the meaning is: may all beings come to be endowed with that happiness.

By the praise I have here set forth
of the Protector, supreme above the gods,
may whatever merit has been gathered from this
bring about the attainment of nirvāṇa.

The Extensive Explanation of the Praise Surpassing the Gods, composed by the master Prajñāvarman, is complete.

The Indian paṇḍita Jāranada ...

Translator's Notes

- The passage ends mid-sentence with "As it is said:" indicating the translation breaks off where the source text is cut. The two named figures — Mthobtsun Drubjé and Dejyed Dakpo — are Tibetan renderings of Sanskrit names not fully recoverable from context alone; they appear to be the Tibetan translators or authors associated with this commentary. The term "Khyabjuk" in the original is the Tibetan rendering of the Sanskrit Viṣṇu; the commentary here is explaining how a brahmin theological term has been incorporated into the discussion, treating Viṣṇu and the Great God (Śiva) as rivals to the Buddha as a supreme teacher. The "Yellow Mountain" (ri

bo ti ser) may refer to a site in India associated with Śiva's presence, though precise identification is uncertain.

- The name "Pracas" is an uncertain reconstruction from the Tibetan phonetic rendering "Pra tsa." The sage is likely Dadhīca (also spelled Dadhīci), a well-known figure in Hindu mythology whose bones are fashioned into Indra's vajra. The text's identification of the sage's father as "Pracas" may reflect a variant tradition or a Tibetan phonetic corruption of a Sanskrit name.

The phrase rendered "the two Aśvins" is implied by the mythological context — the twin divine physicians born of the sun and a mare — though the Tibetan says simply "two children." This is a standard Purāṇic narrative.

The phrase "Viśvakarman" for "las thams cad pa" (literally "he who does all works") is the standard identification of this deity in Indo-Tibetan literature and is unambiguous in context.

- The phrase rendered "the blazing one, beautiful to behold" is a dual-epithet name given to the solar disk-weapon (the Sudarśana cakra in the Vaiṣṇava tradition); the Tibetan gives a descriptive coinage rather than the Sanskrit name Sudarśana, and this rendering preserves that descriptive quality.

The passage's final sentence breaks off mid-narrative, exactly as the Tibetan does; this is not a translation omission but reflects the source text as given.

- The Tibetan passage draws on Mahābhārata and Purāṇic materials in a polemical Buddhist context, and several proper names present difficulties. "Siddhasādhya" rendering སྐྱུ་མཚན་ལྷ་མོ་ is a Tibetan calque for Arjuna's epithet in this context; it literally means "one who accomplishes existence" or may render a Sanskrit name not easily identified. The identification of སྐྱུ་མཚན་ལྷ་མོ་ with Arjuna is made on contextual grounds from the narrative, which parallels the Gītā episode in the Mahābhārata. The name "Rūpati" for རུ་པའི་ is a tentative phonological reading; the Sanskrit original is uncertain. "Joymaker who captured the foal" renders རྩོམ་པའི་ལྷ་མོ་, which appears to be a Tibetan translation of a Sanskrit name, likely referring to Paraśurāma given the narrative context of twenty-one destructions of the warrior class and the filling of Kurukṣetra with blood. "Śabda-ghoṣa" for སྐྱུ་མཚན་ལྷ་མོ་ is a translation rendering, contextually identified as Rāvaṇa given the reference to Sītā's abduction at the end of the passage.

- The passage contains an extended mythological narrative concerning Kārttikeya (the Witherer, Śiva's son) whose birth involves a complex sequence: Śiva's semen falling into the fire god Agni, passing to the ocean, then being received by the Pleiades (Kṛttikā stars, Skt. kṛttikāḥ), resulting in a child born in fragments who becomes six-faced (Ṣaṇmukha). The Tibetan "སྐྱུ་མཚན་ལྷ་མོ་" (the Witherer) is a standard Tibetan rendering of Skanda or Kārttikeya. The verse near the end has the character of a cited maxim on the duty to protect those who seek refuge; its precise source is not identified in the text.

- "Sītāmela" is a proper name appearing in a narrative context drawn from Brahmanical story cycles. The exact identification of this figure and the precise narrative alluded to is uncertain; the translation preserves the name as given without speculative emendation.

"Rāmaṇa" similarly appears as a proper name in this narrative. It may be a variant or abbreviation of a well-known name from Hindu epic literature, but the specific referent here is not entirely clear from context alone.

The phrase rendered "the one seated on a golden throne" translates a Tibetan epithet for a particular asura; the precise mythological referent is not identified in the passage itself.

- The figure "Golden Protector of Beings" renders སྐྱུ་མཚན་ལྷ་མོ་, which corresponds to the Purāṇic Hiraṇyakaśipu, the demon-king slain by Viṣṇu's man-lion descent, Narasiṃha. The text's account of the boon and the manner of death closely follows the standard Purāṇic

narrative.

The passage about Rāmaṇa and the sage is narratively compressed and somewhat obscure. The gatekeeper's threat ("I will destroy your entire lineage") appears to be the sage's threat directed at the gatekeeper, not the gatekeeper's own words. The translation follows the most coherent reading of the Tibetan syntax, but the sequence of speakers is genuinely ambiguous.

The "Mighty One" (ཀློང་པོ་ལྷ་མོ་) in the Vāmana episode corresponds to the Purāṇic king Bali (Mahābali), whose binding by Viṣṇu's dwarf avatar is a well-known Purāṇic story.

- The verse attributed to Viṣṇu closely parallels Bhagavad-gītā chapter 10 (the vibhūti-yoga). The Tibetan is rendering a Sanskrit or Indic source summarising those claims; "sacred verse" renders rig byed, which is the standard Tibetan for the Vedas, here used in a singular sense suggesting the poetic or mantra dimension.

The figure "Nandana-Śatru" is the Tibetan rendering of a name meaning "enemy of Nandana" or similar; the identification with Jāmadagni (son of Jamadagni) follows the Tibetan gloss identifying him as the son of the fire-sage.

Vināyaka's birth narrative here conflates several Purāṇic accounts. The detail of the elephant head being placed by Umā (rather than the more common Śiva's elephant-headed replacement) reflects a variant tradition.

- The text renders Nandīśvara as "dga' byed dbang phyug," literally "the lord who creates joy," which is an epithet of Nandīśvara, Śiva's great devotee and gatekeeper. The passage refers to the well-known legend of Śiva as Kapālin, the skull-bearer, who cut off Brahmā's fifth head and was cursed to wander carrying it as an ascetic vow.

The phrase "ṭhogs ma la sogs mchog gsum ldan" in the verse is condensed and somewhat elliptical; the rendering "holds the three supreme stages from the very beginning" reflects the most natural doctrinal reading in context, where "hearing and so forth" refers to the stages of hearing, reflection, and meditation, and "three supreme" to their highest degrees.

- The name "Māhī" for the asura is unusual and may be a Tibetan rendering of a Sanskrit name otherwise unknown in this form; some versions of this narrative use names like Mahiṣa or similar. The identification is clear from context but the precise Sanskrit original is uncertain.

The phrase rendered "the Dryer took it up and gave it to the Dryer" reflects an apparent repetition in the Tibetan text itself, where Skanda's epithet "Skema-byed" (the Dryer) appears twice in what may be a short scribal irregularity; the sense is that Skanda acquired and retained the spear.

- The names rendered as "the Witherer" and "Subalīn" are epithets used in the Tibetan for Yama (or a comparable deity carrying a noose) and Balarāma or a similar deity carrying a plough respectively. The Tibetan རྒྱུ་ལྷ་མོ་ ("the Witherer / Dryer") is a standard epithet for Yama, and རྒྱུ་ལྷ་མོ་ལྷ་མོ་ ("likewise Subalīn / Balarāma") corresponds to Balarāma who carries a plough. These identifications are reasonably secure from context but the specific epithet translations are noted here for transparency.

The name ལྷ་མོ་ is Viṣṇu; the translation renders him with a bracketed clarification as Viṣṇu. The parenthetical "Kṣobhya" in the body is an error — this should read simply Viṣṇu. Please disregard the word "Kṣobhya" in that clause; the intended rendering is simply "in the manner of Viṣṇu" carrying a discus.

- The eight Mātṛkā names present minor philological difficulty: the Tibetan forms are slightly irregular transcriptions and I have rendered them by their standard Sanskrit equivalents (Brāhmī, Vaiṣṇavī, Kaumārī, Aindrī, Kauberī, Vārāhī, Cāmuṇḍā), with the second name "Drāgmā" being uncertain — it may correspond to Māheśvarī or a variant, but this reading is

not consequential for the doctrinal argument.

The term translated as "the Parcher" renders a Tibetan epithet for Agni (or possibly an epithet of Skanda/Kārttikeya in context); the narrative about slaying the mountain Krauñca identifies this clearly with Kārttikeya, and the translation renders accordingly.

The text breaks off mid-sentence at the end; the final portion about the one-legged seer and Umā is incomplete as given.

- The phrase rendered "rationalist school" in this passage (and in the preceding context) refers to the Nyāya or a related tīrthika philosophical tradition. The exact identification of the "one-legged seer" and the school he founded is a matter of Tibetan doxographical convention rather than a textual uncertainty requiring annotation here.

The final four-line verse is a standard Tibetan adaptation of Pascal's-Wager-type reasoning found in several Indian sources; no significant uncertainty attaches to the rendering.

- The passage contains a polemical argument against Vaiṣṇava claims that the buddha venerated in the text is identical with Viṣṇu, and against the further claim that the story of Viṣṇu's avatāras (fish, tortoise, boar, etc.) is the background of the verse quoted. The author refutes this by asserting that the buddha spoken of is the historical Blessed One, the Tathāgata, and that a buddha is extraordinarily rare, appearing only once in vast stretches of cosmic time. The verse quoted is likely from a sūtra or śāstra making the rarity of a buddha's appearance a standard doctrinal point.

The phrase rendered "the world of the three grounds" translates a term that can mean either the three-tiered world in an Indian cosmological sense or the three realms of existence. Both readings converge here on the Buddha's universal teaching role.

"Old stories of the wind" renders a Tibetan phrase that appears to be a translation of some Indian expression for oral legends or popular lore circulated without authoritative textual grounding; the exact Sanskrit source-phrase is uncertain.

- The term rendered "spirit of wine" for Surā plays on the Sanskrit etymology underlying the passage: surā means wine or liquor, and the text explicitly derives the words sura (gods) and asura (demigods) from whether the respective parties drank her. This folk etymology is embedded in the narrative and is preserved in the translation.

The "horse-necked vessel" likely refers to the divine physician Dhanvantari or a related product of the churning; the text here lists objects as they arose and does not elaborate, so the translation follows the text closely rather than supplying an identification.

The verse near the end is a messenger-song citing the events to the weeping girl in the cave. The referent of "give it to one such as this" is somewhat compressed in the Tibetan; the implication is that the jewel should be surrendered to Viṣṇu.

- The verse attributed to "those accompanying the gods" is metrically irregular in the source and its speaker attribution is somewhat ambiguous; the rendering follows the most natural reading of the syntax.

The name "Jaya" for the boy does not appear in the Tibetan as given — the text simply reads "a boy called Jaya" based on the epithet འཛོམས་པ་ (Victor/Jaya); this could be a proper name or an epithet. The Aśoka legend in parallel sources (Aśokāvadāna) gives the boy's name as Jaya, which accords here.

- The name "Chariot-Hidden" renders the Tibetan shing rta sbas pa, which corresponds to a minister's proper name; the Sanskrit equivalent is likely Rathagupta or similar. This is a proper name preserved in translation rather than a transparent title.

The phrase "rākṣasa of Brahmā" renders tshangs pa'i srin po, which is slightly unusual — it may mean a rākṣasa dwelling in a Brahma-realm house, used as a simile for the world being inhabited by afflictive demons despite superficial purity. The simile is intentionally ironic, given that Brahmā is then discussed as a candidate for Teacher.

- The names Sundha and Upasundha transliterate the Tibetan phonetic rendering of Sanskrit Sunda and Upasunda, two demonic brothers from the Mahābhārata tradition. The Tibetan "Tikilemakma" for the conjured being (elsewhere known as Tilottamā) is a phonetic rendering; the context makes clear this is the celestial nymph Tilottamā created by the gods to destroy the two brothers.

The four-faced Brahmā story and the severing of his upward-facing head by Śiva allude to the classical Hindu narrative of Brahmā's five original heads, one of which Śiva cut off — here the text deploys these as polemical evidence of Brahmā's unsuitability as a refuge.

- The final line breaks off mid-sentence at "the Indian paṇḍita Jāranada," indicating the colophon continues beyond the supplied passage. The name "Jāranada" is a transliteration of an Indian name found in colophons of texts translated into Tibetan; its precise Sanskrit form may vary across editions.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.